Working with words | Discussing working practices

3

Starting point

1 What do you like or dislike about your place of work? Think about space, layout, lighting, equipment, noise, etc.

2 What does 'flexible working' mean to you?

3 Will the way you work in the future be different? If so, how and why?

1 ***How good is your organization at changing with the times? Read the article and decide to what extent the statements are true for your company.***

CORPORATE CULTURE

Quite a few organizations invest in new offices and information systems in order to improve efficiency, but they do comparatively little to **transform** a corporate culture that is often rooted in a previous era. Others seek to **implement** innovations in their working practices and **procedures** – such as flexible hours, teleworking, policies for work-life balance – without **putting in place** the necessary infrastructure of facilities and technology. Some companies manage to combine a poor infrastructure with an aversion to any kind of cultural change. But of course there are a few that get it right, combining both innovative working practices and the **means** to make them work.

But what about you? Read these statements and decide to what extent they apply to where you work.

1 The company buildings create a **dynamic** working atmosphere.
2 Staff are judged by the hours they work, not what they achieve.
3 Staff need to have excellent IT skills.
4 In order to be able to work here you need to **access** paper files.
5 Staff can work wherever and whenever is most **effective** for the job in hand.
6 Meetings have a sense of **purpose**, and result in decisions.
7 The demands of working at the company put pressure on people's home lives.
8 Seamless technology across all our sites enables us to perform competitively.
9 Most staff aren't given the **option** to work flexible hours.
10 Staff are consulted before any new procedures are put in place.

2 ***Find words in bold in the text in the box are similar in meaning to the words in italics in sentences 1-10.***

We need to come up with ways of being more *efficient* in our work.
We're *entering* quite a difficult period, and there are plenty of challenges ahead.
At the interview you have to prove you have the *ability* to do the job well.
We like to give all staff the *opportunity* to come back to us with any comments.
We have *changed* the job description quite significantly.
It's important to *carry out* thorough research before redesigning jobs.
It's quite a lengthy *process* from agreeing the changes to implementing them.
I don't really understand the *meaning* of the last paragraph.
He's in his sixties, but he's still an *energetic* man with lots of new ideas.
Call IT and ask them to *install* all the software you need.

transform
implement
procedure
putting in place
mean
dynamic
access
effective
purpose
option

Can you use the words in bold from the text in the sentences in 2? If so, does the meaning change?

3 ***Iñaki Lozano is the Managing Director of BICG, a Madrid-based consultancy firm specializing in new ways of working. BICG have led numerous international strategic consulting and research projects across the world. They have developed some of the most innovative ways-of-working strategies to date.***

What three organizational aspects of companies do BICG focus on?

Why is their work necessary, and what are the advantages?

Who is most likely to resist and embrace change?

4 ***Listen to the interview again. What nouns collocate with verbs 1-8?***

1. accommodate _____
2. achieve _____
3. anticipate _____
4. facilitate _____
5. generate _____
6. exchange _____
7. assess _____
8. measure _____

5 ***Match the verbs in 6 to other nouns (a-h) that they collocate with.***

a _____ targets / objectives
b _____ special requirements / requests
c _____ ideas / interest
d _____ knowledge / points of view
e _____ progress / productivity
f _____ development / growth
g _____ performance / a situation
h _____ potential difficulties / objections

Work with a partner. Make sentences using the collocations from 6 and 7 to say how you could make your organization more efficient.

6 ***Work with a partner. You work for a manufacturing company which has a problem with morale in the factory. Read about the possible causes in the email, then follow steps 1-3.***

1. Briefly outline the main points.
2. Discuss possible approaches to improve morale.
3. Decide on an action plan for change.

Dear all

Following a series of low productivity figures, I've been looking into the situation in the factory. I have talked to a number of staff and the general impression is that they are not motivated and they are doing the bare minimum to achieve their daily targets. From my point of view, this seems to be a self-perpetuating cycle of low morale – the figures are down so the supervisors are applying more pressure, which means people feel less valued, etc. Anyway, I thought I ought to let you know my findings so far below. Let me know if you'd like to discuss this further.

Regards

Brian

Some of the major factors causing low morale may be:

- the impact of recent technical changes in production
- issues related to work-life balance
- working by output/result, not by time spent
- cost-saving initiatives
- instability of jobs in the sector